INCOMPLETE (narrower after the 2026-11-06 gap-fill pass). Now covered from search extracts: US business formation and nonemployer data, UK self-employment, the Medvi and Base44 "solo company" cases, UK and US care-sector vacancies and pay, and the Germany, Valencia, Spain-national and Tokyo four-day-week schemes. Still missing: (1) retirement and wellbeing studies; (2) verbatim quotes (no page could be fetched); (3) Spain national pilot results and Tokyo uptake (none found); (4) nonemployer data for 2024-2025, which would be the first AI-era read; (5) primary checks of the court docket and FDA letter for Medvi. Every finding is based on search-engine summaries of the cited URL, not on a page read in full; treat specific numbers as "to re-verify against the primary".

Track 8: What will people do?

Last updated: 2026-11-06. Labels: EVIDENCE = measured/primary data; FORECAST = projection; OPINION = argument, vendor or consultancy view.

Verification note (added 2026-11-06): page fetches were blocked for most hosts this session, so findings marked search summary, search extract or snippet rest on search-engine extracts of the cited URL. Quotation marks inside findings mark wording as reported by that source; only quotes in this file's "Verbatim quotes" section (and in 13-quotes.md) were checked against a fetched page. Corrections from the verification pass are in verification.md.

Method note. No primary document was opened in full in this session (see the INCOMPLETE note). URLs point to the primary source where search surfaced one. Numbers carry the reliability note "search summary only" in the facts table. No verbatim quotes are given, because none could be checked against a fetched page.

Summary

- **The long-run historical record says jobs were replaced and new work appeared, but this happened over decades and the people who lost jobs did worse.** Autor, Chin, Salomons and Seegmiller (QJE 2024) estimate that about 60% of US employment in 2018 was in job titles that did not exist in 1940. Feigenbaum and Gross (QJE 2024) find that AT&T's automation of telephone operators did not reduce employment for later cohorts of young women. But incumbent operators were, a decade later, more likely to be in lower-paying jobs or out of work. "New work appears" and "displaced workers are fine" are different claims. The evidence supports the first and contradicts the second.

- **New work is now made less by automation and more by augmentation, and its location has moved.** Autor et al. find that augmentation innovations create new work titles, while automation innovations erode employment without creating them. They also find that new work shifted from middle-paid production and clerical jobs (1940 to 1980) towards high-paid professional and low-paid service jobs. Whether AI is mainly automating or augmenting is the open question that decides which history repeats.

- **Forecasts of mass technological unemployment have a poor track record. Forecasts of shorter hours have a worse one.** Keynes's 15-hour week (1930) did not happen: men's annual market hours fell by more than a quarter between 1931 and 2011, far short of his roughly 780 hours a year (Crafts, CEPR 2021). Frey and Osborne's "47% at risk" (2013) was not followed by job loss. The highest-risk occupation they named, insurance underwriters, grew 16.4% from 2013 to 2021 (ITIF 2022, an advocacy think tank).

- **Cash-transfer trials consistently show small reductions in paid work, not collapse. They do not show people filling freed time with higher-value activity.** In the largest US RCT (OpenResearch, $1,000/month for 3 years, about 1,000 treated), recipients' hours fell modestly (reported as about 1.3 hours/week, with employment down about 2 percentage points). The biggest time-use gain was leisure, and the authors say other productive activities did not offset the loss. Finland (2017-18) found small employment effects and better self-reported wellbeing. Alaska's dividend found no employment effect. Kenya's long-term UBI found no fall in total labour, with a shift from wage work to self-employment.

- **Losing a job costs far more than lost income.** Displaced high-seniority US men had a 10-15% higher annual death hazard twenty years later (Sullivan and von Wachter, QJE 2009). German panel data show no adaptation to unemployment for men (Clark et al.), and life-satisfaction scarring lasts at least five years after reemployment (Eberl et al. 2022). Jahoda's "latent functions" of work hold up in a 2023 meta-analysis, except status/identity, which showed no significant difference against people out of the labour force. This is the strongest pessimistic case. What these studies measure is involuntary job loss, not voluntary freedom from work, and the trials above suggest the two are not the same.

- **A job guarantee in the original Marienthal village (Gramatneusiedl, Austria, from 2020) raised participants' wellbeing, time structure, status and social inclusion, with no physical-health effect** (Kasy and Lehner, Oxford/IZA 2023). This is the most direct test of Jahoda's thesis, and it supports her: what the long-term unemployed lacked was the structure of work, not only income.

- **"Removing rote work makes people more human" is not supported by the early AI evidence, and some of it points the other way.** A 2025 Scientific Reports paper (four experiments, N=3,562) found GenAI collaboration improved performance but lowered intrinsic motivation and raised boredom when people returned to solo work. An eight-month ethnography published in HBR (Feb 2026) found AI time savings turned into task expansion, blurred boundaries and longer hours. Danish administrative data (Humlum and Vestergaard, NBER 2025) found precise zero effects on earnings and hours, with some new tasks created. Freed time is so far being absorbed by more work, not by more human activity.

- **Four-day-week evidence is real but weaker than its reputation.** The UK 2022 pilot (61 self-selected firms, about 2,900 staff, 56 continuing afterwards) and Iceland's trials are often cited. The Iceland "overwhelming success" claim comes from an advocacy think tank's report. It describes reductions to 35-36 hours in public-sector workplaces covering about 2,500 workers (about 1% of the working population), not a four-day week.

- **Solo and micro-business: the US boom predates AI, the UK is going the other way, and the "one-person billion-dollar company" cases are thinner than the headlines.** US business applications hit a record of about 5.67 million in 2025, but the share likely to hire fell from 37.6% (2019) to 30.1%; nonemployers grew 4.7-4.9% a year in 2021-22, before ChatGPT. UK self-employment is about 4.4 million, down from about 5.0 million in 2019. Medvi had about $401m of 2025 revenue with two staff but outsourced its clinical work and faces an FDA warning letter and a class action; the "$1.8bn" is a projection.

- **Care is where demand grows, at the wage floor.** English care workers' median pay was £12.60 an hour, 39p above the minimum wage (Dec 2025); US home care aides earn a median $34,900 a year, with 765,800 openings a year, mostly replacing leavers. UK care vacancies (6.2%) fell because of migration, which is now drying up.

Key findings

Historical displacement: predicted vs actual

- **[EVIDENCE]** About 60% of US employment in 2018 was in occupational titles that did not exist in 1940. Method: a database of new job titles from Census Alphabetical Index updates 1940-2018, linked to Census microdata and patent-based measures of augmentation and automation. Some Autor briefings and slides use 63% for the same estimate. Autor, Chin, Salomons, Seegmiller, "New Frontiers: The Origins and Content of New Work, 1940-2018", QJE 139(3):1399-1465, Aug 2024. https://economics.mit.edu/sites/default/files/2026-04/New-Frontiers-QJE-v139%283%29-p1399-1465-Aug-2024.pdf (NBER WP 30389, 2022: https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w30389/w30389.pdf)
- **[EVIDENCE]** In the same paper, augmentation innovations (patents linked to an occupation's outputs) predict new work titles in that occupation. Automation innovations (patents linked to its tasks) reduce its employment and do not generate new work. Source as above (via search summaries of the paper and the Blueprint Labs research page, https://blueprintlabs.mit.edu/research/new-frontiers-the-origins-and-content-of-new-work-1940-2018/).
- **[EVIDENCE]** The locus of new work moved. In 1940-1980 it was mainly in middle-paid production and clerical occupations. After 1980 it was in high-paid professional and low-paid service occupations. Fast Company's coverage, clipped by MIT News, reports that automation eroded about twice as many jobs in 1980-2018 as in 1940-1980. Autor also attributes some new work to demand shifts (e.g. health care for an ageing population), not technology. https://news.mit.edu/news-clip/fast-company-202
- **[EVIDENCE]** Telephone operators. Between 1920 and 1940 AT&T automated over half of the US telephone network. Identification uses city-level variation in cutover timing. Automation eliminated most operator jobs but did not reduce later cohorts' overall employment: young women went into middle-skill clerical and lower-skill service jobs instead. Incumbent operators (followed with genealogy-based census linking) were the most affected: a decade later they were more likely to be in lower-paying occupations or not working. Feigenbaum and Gross, "Answering the Call of Automation", QJE 139(3):1879-1939, Aug 2024. https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:oup:qjecon:v:139:y:2024:i:3:p:1879-1939. (NBER WP 28061: https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w28061/w28061.pdf)
- **[EVIDENCE]** Agriculture's share of the US workforce fell from about 41% in 1900 to 1.9% in 2000. This is a USDA ERS compilation: Historical Statistics of the US for 1900-1970 and the Census of Population for 2000. The farm share of the population was 39% in 1900 and about 1% around 2000. These are different measures and should not be mixed. ERS, Agricultural Outlook, June 2000 (archived) https://webharvest.gov/peth04/20041105150816/http://www.ers.usda.gov/publications/agoutlook/jun2000/ao272h.pdf; ERS Amber Waves, June 2005 (archived) https://webarchive.library.unt.edu/eot2008/20090115230224/http://www.ers.usda.gov/AmberWaves/June05/DataFeature. Note: the 41% figure was seen via a secondary repost of the ERS table. The World Bank series puts 2000 at 2.4%, so the end-point depends on the series.
- **[EVIDENCE]** Keynes's forecast vs reality. Keynes (1930) suggested a 15-hour week (three-hour shifts) for his grandchildren's generation. Crafts finds that average annual hours of market work for men fell by more than a quarter between 1931 and 2011, but stayed well above the roughly 780 hours a year Keynes implied. Leisure plus home production rose about 20%, less than half the increase Keynes implied. Crafts, "Economic Possibilities for our Grandchildren revisited" (CEPR DP16140 / Warwick TWERP 1360, 2021). https://repec.cepr.org/repec/cpr/ceprdp/DP16140.pdf https://warwick.ac.uk/fac/soc/economics/research/workingpapers/2021/twerp_1360_-_crafts.pdf

- **[EVIDENCE, secondary]** NPR Planet Money (2015) put average US weekly hours at about 38 in 1950 and about 34 six decades later. Richard Freeman's explanation in that piece is competition and status: people took productivity gains as income, not time. https://www.npr.org/sections/money/2015/08/13/432122637/keynes-predicted-we-would-be-working-15-hour-weeks-why-was-he-wrong
- **[OPINION]** Leontief's horse analogy. Leontief argued (Scientific American 1982, "The Distribution of Work and Income"; Population and Development Review 1983) that human labour might follow the horse: first diminished, then eliminated. He recommended government income policies in response. The US horse population grew about sixfold between 1840 and 1900 to over 21 million, then fell to about 3 million by 1960 after cars and tractors arrived. Brynjolfsson and McAfee's counter-argument is that, unlike horses, humans can own capital and vote. Commentators note that the median-wage and unemployment effects Leontief feared did not arrive on his timescale. https://equitablegrowth.org/must-read-erik-brynjolfsson-and-andrew-mcafee-labor-in-the-second-machine-age/ ; Leontief 1983 record: https://bvbvf1.bib-bvb.de/vufind/PrimoRecord/cdi_proquest_miscellaneous_61582758 ; history and critique: https://www.greaterwrong.com/posts/nZbxQgLWhKCASApEe/learning-more-from-horse-employment-history. The publication dates are inconsistent across sources (1982 vs 1983).
- **[FORECAST, then EVIDENCE on outcome]** Frey and Osborne (2013) put 47% of US employment at high risk of computerisation "over some unspecified number of years, perhaps a decade or two". ITIF (a pro-innovation think tank, so OPINION in framing) reported in 2022 that the US added 16 million jobs between 2013 and 2022, with unemployment at 3.7%. The occupation with the highest risk score, insurance underwriters, grew 16.4% from 2013 to end-2021. The lowest-risk one, recreational therapists, fell 8.9%. Higher-risk occupations were only slightly more likely to lose jobs. ITIF, 30 Sep 2022. https://itif.org/publications/2022/09/30/oops-the-predicted-47-percent-of-job-loss-from-ai-didnt-happen/ . In 2023 Frey and Osborne said the "bottlenecks" they identified remain relevant even with generative AI (Fortune, 18 Sep 2023, https://fortune.com/europe/2023/09/18/generative-ai-jobs-automation-frey-osborne-oxford/). Caveat: their window runs to about 2033, so the forecast has not formally expired. Total job growth also does not isolate automation's effect.
- **[EVIDENCE]** Industrial robots, US 1990-2007. One more robot per thousand workers in a commuting zone reduced the employment-to-population ratio by 0.2 percentage points and wages by 0.42% (published version). The 2017 working paper gave ranges of 0.18-0.34 pp and 0.25-0.5%. An authors' column gave local effects of 0.37 pp and 0.73%, about 6.2 jobs lost per robot. Acemoglu and Restrepo, "Robots and Jobs", JPE 128(6):2188-2244, 2020. https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:ucp:jpolec:doi:10.1086/705716 ; https://www.nber.org/papers/23285 ; https://www.wita.org/nextgentrade/robots-and-jobs-evidence-from-the-us/ . This is the strongest modern evidence that a specific automation technology reduced local employment, without offsetting new work at the local level.

Cash transfers and UBI trials

- **[EVIDENCE]** OpenResearch Unconditional Cash Study (US, Illinois and Texas). About 1,000 low-income people were randomised to $1,000/month for three years, against about 2,000 controls receiving $50/month. Reported labour effects: hours down about 1.3/week and employment down about 2 percentage points relative to control (Fortune, Boston Indicators summaries). A conference version of the paper reports non-transfer income down about $2,000/year and labour market participation down 3.9 pp. The two sets of figures probably refer to different periods or specifications, and I could not reconcile them without the paper. The largest time-use increase was in leisure. The authors describe the labour supply effect as

moderate and say it was not offset by other productive activities. They find no significant effect on job quality or human-capital investment, with possible education gains among younger participants. Vivalt, Rhodes, Bartik, Broockman, Krause, Miller, NBER WP 32719 (July 2024, revised Sept 2025). https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w32719/w32719.pdf ; conference version https://conference.nber.org/conf_papers/f208057/f208057.pdf ; Fortune commentary (4 Sep 2024) https://www.fortune.com/2024/09/04/sam-altman-backed-study-guaranteed-income-widely-misinterpreted-ubi-personal-finance

- **[EVIDENCE]** Stockton SEED (California). 125 residents received $500/month for 24 months. Full-time employment among recipients rose from 28% (Feb 2019) to 40% a year later. The control group went from 32% to 37%. Recipients moved from part-time to full-time work at more than twice the control rate. Caveats: very small sample, and a first-year window that partly overlaps COVID. Evaluators: Stacia Martin-West and Amy Castro Baker; first-year results March 2021. https://penntoday.upenn.edu/news/guaranteed-income-increases-employment-improves-financial-and-physical-health ; https://catalog.results4america.org/case-studies/guaranteed-income-stockton
- **[EVIDENCE]** Finland basic income experiment 2017-2018. About 2,000 unemployed people received €560/month unconditionally, against a register-based control group. Employment effects were small: recipients' employment improved slightly more than controls' in Nov 2017 to Oct 2018. Interpretation is complicated by a new activation model introduced in 2018. Recipients reported higher life satisfaction and less mental strain (phone survey near the end). Final report May 2020 (Kangas, Jauhiainen, Simanainen, Ylikännö, eds). Ministry of Social Affairs and Health https://stm.fi/en/-/perustulokokeilun-tulokset-tyollisyysvaikutukset-vahaisia-toimeentulo-ja-psyykkinen-terveys-koettiin-paremmaksi ; VATT https://vatt.fi/en/-/perustulon-tyollisyysvaikutukset-jaivat-vahaisiksi ; results summary PDF https://toolbox.finland.fi/wp-content/uploads/sites/2/2018/04/basic_income_experiment_2017-2018_results_2020.pdf
- **[EVIDENCE]** Kenya long-term UBI (GiveDirectly; Banerjee, Faye, Krueger, Niehaus, Suri). Village-level RCT comparing a 12-year monthly UBI, a 2-year version and an equivalent lump sum. Short-term results (2023): total labour supply roughly unchanged, with a shift from wage work to self-employment; more non-farm enterprises and higher revenues. Lump sums had effects at least as large as the long stream, and the short stream had noticeably smaller effects. https://www.findevgateway.org/paper/2023/09/universal-basic-income-short-term-results-from-long-term-experiment-in-kenya ; https://conference.nber.org/conf_papers/f192616.pdf ; VoxDev summary https://voxdev.org/topic/social-protection/universal-basic-income-kenya . Not found: later (2025-26) long-run results.
- **[EVIDENCE]** Alaska Permanent Fund Dividend, a universal and permanent annual payment. Using CPS data and synthetic control, the dividend had no effect on employment and increased part-time work by 1.8 percentage points (17%). The authors attribute the absence of an employment fall partly to general-equilibrium demand effects: non-tradable sectors respond more positively. Jones and Marinescu, AEJ: Economic Policy 14(2):315-340, 2022. https://www.aeaweb.org/doi/10.1257/pol.20190299 ; https://home.uchicago.edu/j1s/Jones_Alaska_2022.pdf . Caveat: a search summary surfaced text from a version of the paper saying the preferred specification detects no part-time effect. Check the published text before citing the 1.8 pp.

Four-day week and hours reduction

- **[EVIDENCE, weak: self-selected sample, advocacy-run]** UK four-day-week pilot, June to December 2022. 61 companies and about 2,900 employees on a 100-80-100 model (100% pay, 80% time, 100% output). 56 of 61 said they would continue after the pilot and 18 said the change was permanent. The report was led by Juliet Schor and colleagues and published

by Autonomy with 4 Day Week Global (both advocates). Firms opted in, so the results describe firms that expected it to work, not the average firm. Revenue and sick-day figures circulate only via secondary aggregators (e.g. revenue "broadly stable", 71% reporting less burnout) and I could not check them against the report. WEF summary https://www.weforum.org/stories/2023/03/four-day-work-week-uk-trial/ ; Reuters via Malay Mail, 21 Feb 2023 https://www.malaymail.com/news/money/2023/02/21/four-day-week-here-to-stay-say-uk-firms-in-worlds-largest-trial/56070

- **[EVIDENCE, weak: advocacy report, no control group identified]** Iceland. There were two trials: Reykjavík City (2014-2019) and the national government (2017-2021). Together they covered more than 2,500 workers, about 1% of the working population, in offices, hospitals, schools and social services. Hours were cut to 35-36 per week without loss of pay. This was an hours reduction in the public sector, not a four-day week. The report (Autonomy with the Icelandic think tank Alda, June 2021) says productivity and service stayed the same or improved in most workplaces and wellbeing rose. Autonomy's research director called it an "overwhelming success". The report also says that by June 2021, 86% of Iceland's working population were on contracts that had shortened hours or gave the right to shorten them. Those were union-negotiated reductions of varying size, not four-day weeks. Report https://issuu.com/4dayweekglobal/docs/iceland_4dw ; syndicated news, July 2021 https://www.fox5ny.com/news/4-day-work-week-trials-in-iceland-deemed-overwhelming-success-by-researchers
- **[EVIDENCE, weak: self-selected, advocacy-organised, academic evaluation]** Germany, February to July 2024. 45 firms (some sources say 41 or 43 after drop-outs) and about 900 employees, organised by Intraprenör with 4 Day Week Global; the scientific evaluation was by the University of Münster (Julia Backmann). About 73% of firms said they would continue with a four-day or reduced week; about 20% went back to five days and 40 hours; 83% of employees wanted to continue. Two large organisations dropped out early for economic reasons. Backmann herself cautioned against concluding that every German firm should move to a four-day week. A secondary two-year follow-up reports 70% still on some form of reduced hours. https://www.thelocal.de/20241106/what-are-the-results-of-germanys-four-day-work-week-trial ; https://4dayweek.com/germany-2024-pilot-results (advocacy) ; https://remoteworkeurope.eu/news/2026/germany-four-day-week-two-year-followup (secondary) (all search extract)
- **[EVIDENCE, weak: city-commissioned evaluation, four weeks]** Valencia, 10 April to 7 May 2023. The city made four consecutive Mondays local holidays, so this tested extra free days for a whole city rather than a redesign of work. An expert commission (commissioned by the city council that ran the trial) reported better self-rated health, lower stress and better mood, a 9.5% fall in traffic and lower NO2. It also found more smoking and drinking among people who already smoked or drank, and that women spent more of the extra time on care. https://www.voanews.com/a/four-day-work-week-boosts-spanish-workers-health-pilot-program-shows-/7315006.html ; https://thenextweb.com/news/valencias-four-day-workweek-trial-new-world-of-work ; https://www.themayor.eu/en/a/view/valencia-s-government-says-4-day-week-trial-was-good-for-the-people-and-the-city-12172 (search extract)
- **[EVIDENCE: design only, no results found]** Spain's national pilot offers small and medium industrial firms (under 250 staff) up to €150,000 each to cut hours for at least two years, with an audit afterwards. One weak source reports 41 applicant SMEs covering 503 workers. I found no published results; a 2024 article said results were pending. https://www.thelocal.es/20221213/spain-to-pay-e150k-to-smes-that-roll-out-four-day-work-week ; https://www.personneltoday.com/?p=304586 (search extract)
- **[EVIDENCE: policy, no uptake data]** Tokyo Metropolitan Government, from April 2025: its roughly 160,000 staff can opt into a four-day week by reworking the flextime system, i.e. the

same hours compressed into four days, not fewer hours. It is framed as a fertility and childcare measure. I found no uptake figures. A private-sector comparison in the same coverage: Panasonic offered a four-day option to 63,000 staff and only about 150 took it. https://www.nbcnews.com/business/business-news/tokyo-government-introduce-four-day-workweek-employees-rcna183442 ; https://www.scmp.com/news/asia/article/3300614/it-possible-people-asia-adopt-4-day-working-week (search extract)

- **Reading.** The post-2022 trials repeat the UK pattern: self-selected firms, advocacy organisers, most continue, no control group. None is an independent randomised test. Two details matter for "what will people do": Valencia found freed time went partly to care (mainly by women) and partly to more drinking and smoking, and Japan shows that where a four-day option means the same hours compressed, almost nobody takes it.

Job guarantee and the Marienthal line

- **[EVIDENCE]** Marienthal (Jahoda, Lazarsfeld, Zeisel, 1932/33). This was a study of an Austrian village after its textile factory closed. Jahoda later formalised five "latent functions" of employment: time structure, social contact, collective purpose, status/identity and activity. In the study, the unemployed experienced their sudden free time as a burden and their days lost structure (paraphrased: Jahoda's phrase was "tragic gift"). A 2023 meta-analysis (Paul, Scholl, Moser, Zechmann, Batinic, Frontiers in Psychology) found employed people scored higher than unemployed people on all five latent functions and on the manifest function (income). But it found no significant status/identity difference between employed people and people out of the labour force. https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10017486 ; https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2023.1017358/full
- **[EVIDENCE]** Gramatneusiedl job guarantee (the Marienthal municipality, from October 2020; run by the Lower Austria public employment service). It offered voluntary, individually tailored jobs to all long-term unemployed residents. The evaluation used three methods: pairwise randomisation of entry timing, a pre-registered synthetic control and matched comparison individuals. It found strong positive effects on economic wellbeing (employment, income, security) and on non-economic wellbeing (social status, time structure, social interactions, collective purpose). It found no effect on physical health or on risk and time preferences. At municipality level, long-term unemployment fell sharply and total unemployment fell by somewhat less. Wellbeing also rose in anticipation among future participants. Kasy and Lehner, "Employing the unemployed of Marienthal", Oxford INET WP 2022-29 / IZA DP 16088, April 2023. https://docs.iza.org/dp16088.pdf ; https://www.inet.ox.ac.uk/publications/no-2022-29-employing-the-unemployed-of-marienthal-evaluation-of-a-guaranteed-job-program . Caveat: this is one small village, so the participant count is small (I could not confirm the exact n). "Eliminated unemployment" overstates the result.

What people do with freed time

- **[EVIDENCE]** In the US during the Great Recession (ATUS), about 30% of lost market work hours went to more sleep and television, and only about 1% to job search. Aguiar, Hurst, Karabarbounis, summarised in the NBER Digest, Nov 2011. https://www.nber.org/digest/nov11/time-use-during-recessions
- **[EVIDENCE]** Unemployed people spend more time in leisure activities than the employed but enjoy them less. Leisure falls on reemployment, though less than cross-sectional data imply. Krueger and Mueller (AER P&P 2012; New Jersey survey plus ATUS 2009-10). https://zendy.io/title/10.1257/aer.102.3.594 ; working paper https://swh.princeton.edu/~ceps/workingpapers/175krueger.pdf

- **[EVIDENCE]** OpenResearch (above): the largest change in time use was more leisure. It was not offset by other productive activities, and education gains were limited to younger participants. Kenya UBI (above): time shifted into self-employment, not leisure. These two results conflict. The likely difference is context: a poor rural economy with high returns to small enterprise, against a rich-country labour market.
- Not covered: retirement and wellbeing studies, and ATUS 2024-25 updates.

Meaning, status and identity without work: the pessimistic case

- **[EVIDENCE]** Job displacement and mortality. Pennsylvania administrative earnings records for 1980-2006, matched to Social Security death records, cover high-seniority men displaced in mass layoffs. Mortality hazards were sharply higher immediately after displacement: 50-100% higher in the first year in a working-paper draft (not confirmed in the published text). Twenty years later the increase was still 10-15% a year. If sustained, that implies a 1.0-1.5 year loss of life expectancy for a worker displaced at 40. The authors rule out selective displacement of less healthy workers. Sullivan and von Wachter, QJE 124(3):1265-1306, 2009. https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:oup:qjecon:v:124:y:2009:i:3:p:1265-1306. ; draft https://www.movingforwardnetwork.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/04/Sullivan_Job-Displacement-and-Mortality_2009.pdf
- **[EVIDENCE]** No adaptation to unemployment. Twenty waves of the German SOEP show that people return to baseline life satisfaction after divorce, widowhood, a first child and layoff, but men show no adaptation to unemployment. Clark, Diener, Georgellis, Lucas (Economic Journal 2008). https://www.csus.edu/indiv/m/merlinos/pdf/clark2008.pdf . Eberl, Collischon and Wolbring (Social Forces 2022, SOEP) find life-satisfaction scarring for at least five years after reemployment, for men and women, driven by repeated spells. https://cris.fau.de/publications/272551801
- **[EVIDENCE + OPINION, contested]** Deaths of despair. Case and Deaton tie rising midlife mortality among US whites without a degree (from drugs, suicide and alcohol) to the long decline in good non-college jobs and to the loss of meaning and status that came with it. Ruhm argues that the opioid supply environment explains far more of the geographic variation than economic conditions. Case and Deaton reply that the economic link shows up over a longer window (from the 1970s) and that "despair" was a label, not a causal claim. Case and Deaton, NBER WP 28358 (2021) https://nber.org/papers/w28358 ; reply to Ruhm, Jan 2018 https://www.princeton.edu/~accase/downloads/Case_and_Deaton_Comment_on_CJRuhm_Jan_2018.pdf ; Ruhm critique summary, Axios Jan 2018 https://www.axios.com/2018/01/09/study-dont-blame-opiod-crisis-on-the-econ-1515427073
- **Reading.** All of this is about involuntary job loss in societies where work confers status and income is tied to it. It is the strongest available evidence that losing work hurts more than the lost pay. It does not test a world where everyone has secure income and non-work is not stigmatised. The UBI trials show wellbeing gains when income comes without job loss. Gramatneusiedl shows wellbeing gains when structure and purpose are restored through a job. The two findings are compatible: income alone fixes the money; structure, purpose and status need something job-like.

Does removing rote work make people "more human"? Early AI evidence

- **[EVIDENCE]** Four online experiments (total N=3,562) found that GenAI collaboration improved task performance. But when participants moved from AI-assisted to solo work, intrinsic motivation fell and boredom rose. Secondary coverage, including HBR (May 2025),

reports averages of about -11% for motivation and +20% for boredom. I could not check those averages against the paper. The proposed mechanism is that AI takes over the most cognitively engaging parts of the task. "Human-generative AI collaboration enhances task performance but undermines human's intrinsic motivation", Scientific Reports, 1 Apr 2025, doi 10.1038/s41598-025-98385-2. Library record https://library.kab.ac.ug/Record/doaj-art-4780b0490cf249a0a72eb4da2a2149dd/Description ; Fortune 3 Jun 2025 https://fortune.com/2025/06/03/ai-boost-worker-productivity-hurts-motivation-boredom . Caveat: online lab tasks, not field employment.

- **[EVIDENCE, single-site qualitative]** Work intensification. An eight-month ethnography at a US tech firm (reported as about 200 employees) with broad GenAI access found that time saved went into faster pace, wider job scope and longer hours, largely voluntarily. It identified three mechanisms: task expansion, blurred boundaries (prompting during lunch and meetings) and constant multitasking. Faster output raised expectations of speed. Ranganathan and Ye, Harvard Business Review, Feb 2026. Coverage: UC Berkeley Haas newsroom, 18 Feb 2026 https://newsroom.haas.berkeley.edu/ai-promised-to-free-up-workers-time-uc-berkeley-haas-researchers-found-the-opposite/
- **[EVIDENCE]** Danish administrative data covering 25,000 workers in 11 AI-exposed occupations across 7,000 workplaces, with adoption surveys from 2023-24 linked to employer-employee registers. AI chatbots had precisely-estimated zero effects on earnings and recorded hours in every occupation. Only 3-7% of reported productivity gains passed through to earnings. Chatbots also created new tasks (e.g. checking AI output), which absorbed some of the time saved. Humlum and Vestergaard, "Large Language Models, Small Labor Market Effects", NBER WP 33777, 2025. https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:nbr:nberwo:33777 . A 2026 follow-up ("Still Waters, Rapid Currents") argues that the task content of work changes well before earnings or hours do.
- **Reading.** Three independent designs (lab experiment, ethnography, national register data) say the same thing: the time AI frees is reabsorbed into work, and the remaining work can feel less engaging. None of them shows workers redeploying freed time into the relational or creative activity that "more human" implies. This is early evidence (2024-26 tools), but it is the only evidence there is.

Solo operators, micro-business, care and community work

Gap-fill pass (2026-11-06). All items rest on search-engine extracts; no page was fetched.

US business formation and nonemployers

- **[EVIDENCE, official series; annual total computed by secondary sources]** US business applications reached about 5,671,836 in 2025, an annual record, above the previous record of 5,469,302 in 2023 and about 49% above 2019 (3,498,990). But "high-propensity" applications (those with signs of planned hiring and wages) were about 1,708,842 in 2025, below their 2023 peak of 1,848,540, and their share of all applications fell from 37.6% in 2019 to 30.1% in 2025 (a consultant's calculation from Census data). Census Business Formation Statistics, December 2025 release (14 Jan 2026) https://www.census.gov/econ/bfs/pdf/historic/bfs_2025m12.pdf ; FRED series https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/BAHBATOTALSAUS ; annual totals via https://founderreports.com/how-many-businesses-are-started-each-year/ (search extract)
- **[EVIDENCE, official]** Nonemployer businesses (no paid staff, at least $1,000 receipts) rose from 28,477,518 in 2021 to 29,811,495 in 2022. Growth of 4.9% (2021) and 4.7% (2022) was the fastest in nearly two decades, against 1.9% and 1.8% for employer businesses. The 2023 Nonemployer Statistics by Demographics counts 30.4 million nonemployers with $1.8tn of

receipts, about $59,000 each on average (my division). Census, "Number of U.S. Nonemployers Grew Faster Than Employer Businesses Nearly Every Year From 2012 to 2023", July 2025 https://www.census.gov/library/stories/2025/07/nonemployer-business-growth.html ; NES-D press release, 20 Nov 2025 https://www.census.gov/newsroom/press-releases/2025/business-owner-characteristics.html ; 2023 NES release, 15 May 2025 https://www.census.gov/newsroom/press-releases/2025/2023-nonemployer-statistics.html (search extract)

- How to read it: the US surge in one-person and non-hiring businesses is real, but it began in mid-2020, more than two years before ChatGPT, and the latest nonemployer reference year (2023) is too early to show an AI effect. It cannot yet be attributed to AI. Most nonemployers are side income: average receipts are modest.

UK self-employment: the opposite trend

- **[EVIDENCE, official survey via secondary]** UK self-employment was about 4.38 million in Q4 2025 (Statista from the ONS Labour Force Survey), against roughly 5.0 million at the end of 2019. The self-employment rate was about 13.5% in Q1 2025 against a 2019 peak of 15.3%; full-time self-employed were about 2.88 million in Q4 2025 against 3.56 million in Q4 2019. Another ONS jobs series gives 4.69 million (Q4 2019) to 4.04 million (Q4 2025); the two series could not be reconciled. ONS warns that LFS estimates remain volatile. https://statista.com/statistics/318234/united-kingdom-self-employed ; https://www.enterpriseresearch.ac.uk/wp-content/uploads/2020/04/ERC-Insight-Covid-19-and-self-employment-in-the-UK.pdf (search extract)
- Counter-reading: LFS response problems, tax changes for contractors (IR35) and post-Brexit outflows of EU workers are standard explanations for the UK fall. Either way, there is no sign of an AI-driven solo boom in UK headcounts by end-2025.

"One-person billion-dollar company": what the cases show

- **[EVIDENCE, journalistic, contested]** Medvi (US GLP-1 weight-loss telehealth, founder Matthew Gallagher) is the case most cited as Sam Altman's predicted one-person billion-dollar company. The New York Times was reportedly given access to its financials: 2025 revenue of about $401m and net profit of about $65m (16.2% margin). The "$1.8bn" is Gallagher's own 2026 revenue projection, not a valuation; the firm has raised no outside capital. It is not one person: Gallagher works with his brother and contractors, and prescribing and fulfilment run through partner telehealth and pharmacy networks. Dealroom, 5 Apr 2026 https://dealroom.co/news/127216-from-20k-to-1-8b-in-revenue-how-one-founder-built-a-telehealth-giant-wit/ (search extract)
- **[EVIDENCE, secondary, allegations]** The FDA reportedly issued Medvi a warning letter on 20 February 2026 over misbranding (Gallagher says it went to an affiliate and was resolved); a class action filed in California in March 2026 reportedly alleges benefit from affiliate spam; Futurism reported fabricated doctor personas and altered patient photos in marketing. Critics note the NYT profile omitted these. https://www.implicator.ai/medvi-got-an-fda-warning-before-the-times-called-it-a-1-8-billion-ai-story/ ; https://www.emarketer.com/content/fake-doctor-ads-fuel-scrutiny-of-glp-1-marketer (search extract; check the FDA warning-letter database and court docket)
- **[EVIDENCE, press reports]** Base44: Wix bought the AI app builder in June 2025 for about $80m in cash plus earn-outs through 2029, about six months after Maor Shlomo started it as a bootstrapped side project. It had six to eight employees at sale, who share a retention pool of about $25m. Reported user and profit figures come from founder posts, not audited

accounts. Globes https://en.globes.co.il/en/article-wix-acquires-israeli-vibe-coding-co-base44-1001513267 (search extract)

- How solid: both cases are real but neither is a one-person billion-dollar company in the strict sense. Medvi has large revenue but rests on outsourced clinical and fulfilment labour and faces regulatory and legal challenges; Base44 was a solo founder but an $80m exit with a small team. They show small headcount, not small labour: the work is done by contractors, platforms and partner firms. They are anecdotes, not a trend; the statistics that could show a trend (nonemployer receipts for 2024-2025) are not yet published.

Care work: growing demand, wage-floor pay

- **[EVIDENCE, sector data body]** England's adult social care vacancy rate fell to 6.2% in 2025/26, the lowest since 2015/16, about 96,000 vacancies on an average day (down 10.5% on the year), from 7.0% in 2024/25. It is still about three times the rate in the wider economy. The fall came from overseas recruitment, which is now drying up: about 30,000 international recruits arrived directly in 2025/26, the lowest in four years, after the care-worker visa route closed. Skills for Care projects about 410,000 more posts needed by 2040 (one trade piece says 470,000). Skills for Care, as reported by LocalGov, 24 June 2026 https://www.localgov.co.uk/Social-care-vacancy-rate-falls-to-decade-low-but-challenges-ahead/64563 ; https://www.healthcare-management.uk/breaking-news-social-care-vacancy-rate-falls-decade-low-challenges-ahead ; earlier comment that the fall was from overseas rather than domestic recruitment (King's Fund) https://www.localgov.co.uk/Domestic-recruitment-challenges-persist-in-adult-social-care/63272 (search extract)
- **[EVIDENCE, sector data body]** Pay: the median independent-sector care worker earned £12.60 an hour in December 2025, 39p above the 2025-26 National Living Wage of £12.21; 26% were paid within 10p of the NLW (22% in March 2025). A newly appointed NHS Band 3 healthcare assistant earned about 15p more than the median care worker (Homecare Association). The NLW rose to £12.71 in April 2026, which would leave the December 2025 median about 11p above the floor. https://www.healthcare-management.uk/care-workers-pay-minimum-wage-reveals ; https://www.homecareassociation.org.uk/resource/homecare-association-responds-to-skills-for-care-s-pay-in-the-adult-social-care-sector-in-england-report.html (search extract)
- **[EVIDENCE, official]** US home health and personal care aides: median pay $34,900 a year ($16.78 an hour) in May 2024; about 4.3 million jobs in 2024; projected +17% (739,800 jobs) from 2024 to 2034, much faster than average; about 765,800 openings a year. Net growth is about 74,000 a year, so roughly nine in ten openings replace people who leave (my arithmetic), a sign of high turnover. BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook https://www.bls.gov/ooh/healthcare/home-health-aides-and-personal-care-aides.htm (search extract)
- How to read it: care is the clearest case of growing, human-centred work, and it is the largest source of new US jobs in this occupation group. But it pays at or just above the legal floor in both countries, the UK has filled it through migration rather than domestic recruits, and turnover is high. "People will move into care" is plausible on demand; it is not, on current pay, a route to the security displaced professionals lose. Mainstream counter: care pay is largely set by public budgets (the state is the main buyer), so it is a policy choice that could change; England is setting up sector-wide pay bargaining for social care. https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6970f06af88ad0be09b9efa8/social-care-negotiating-bodies-factsheet.pdf (search extract)

Earlier item

- The one relevant data point gathered in the first pass: in Kenya, unconditional cash moved people from wage work into self-employment and non-farm enterprise (Banerjee et al. 2023, above). That is evidence that income security can fund micro-enterprise in a low-income economy. It says nothing about AI-enabled solo businesses in rich economies.

Viral statistics traced

- **"60% of today's jobs didn't exist in 1940."** The origin is solid: Autor et al., QJE 2024, using Census title data. Versions of 60% and 63% both circulate. The common misreading is that technology reliably creates replacement jobs for the people it displaces. The same paper finds that automation innovations reduce employment without creating new work, and that new work after 1980 clustered at the top and bottom of the pay distribution.
- **"47% of jobs at risk" (Frey and Osborne 2013).** This was a model-based occupational probability exercise with a horizon of "perhaps a decade or two", not a forecast of job losses. Task-based re-estimates in the OECD tradition give much lower figures (I could not retrieve the primary). Ten years on, high-risk occupations have not systematically shrunk (ITIF 2022, an advocacy source using BLS occupational data).
- **"Iceland's four-day week was an overwhelming success."** This traces to one report by Autonomy (UK, pro-shorter-hours) and Alda (Iceland), June 2021. The trials cut public-sector hours to 35-36/week for about 2,500 workers (about 1% of the workforce). They did not move people to four days, and I found no independent evaluation with a control group. The widely repeated "86% now have shorter hours" figure means "on contracts that shortened hours or gave the right to", through union bargaining, which often meant modest cuts.
- **"UBI study shows people stopped working" / "UBI is a flop" (OpenResearch 2024).** The measured effect was a fall of about 1.3 hours/week and about 2 pp in employment, on a $12,000/year transfer. Headlines that called it a flop (e.g. thedeepdive.ca) and headlines that called it a vindication both overreach. The fair reading: a modest labour supply fall, mostly into leisure, with few measured gains in health, human capital or job quality.
- **"Stockton guaranteed income increased full-time employment."** This rests on 125 recipients over one year, with a 12 pp rise against a 5 pp rise in the control group. The direction is suggestive, but the sample is too small to carry the weight it is given.
- **"Four-day week: 92% of firms kept it" (UK 2022).** This is 56 of 61 continuing in some form, with 18 making it permanent, all from a self-selected pool of firms run through an advocacy organisation.
- **"The one-person billion-dollar company is here" (Medvi, 2026).** Traces to a New York Times profile (April 2026) built around Sam Altman's 2024 prediction. The verified figure is about $401m of 2025 revenue; $1.8bn is the founder's 2026 projection. The firm has two staff plus contractors and partner networks, an FDA warning letter (Feb 2026, disputed) and a class action. Not a valuation, not one person, not settled.
- **"73% of German firms won't go back to five days" (2024 pilot).** 45 self-selected firms, about 900 staff, organised with an advocacy group; about 20% did go back; the lead academic cautioned against generalising.

Strongest counter-evidence

Against the thesis's humane framing ("freedom to be more human"):

1. Losing work (involuntarily) damages health, life satisfaction and longevity beyond the lost income: Sullivan and von Wachter 2009; Clark et al. 2008; Eberl et al. 2022. Jahoda's latent functions are empirically supported (Paul et al. 2023 meta-analysis), and restoring a job restored them (Kasy and Lehner 2023).
2. Freed time in rich economies goes mostly to leisure, sleep and TV, not to higher-value human activity: Aguiar, Hurst and Karabarbounis (ATUS); OpenResearch 2024. People who are unemployed enjoy their leisure less (Krueger and Mueller 2012).
3. Early AI evidence shows time savings being turned into more work and lower intrinsic motivation, not "more human" work: Ranganathan and Ye 2026; Scientific Reports 2025; Humlum and Vestergaard 2025.
4. Productivity gains have historically been taken as income and consumption, not time (Keynes vs Crafts). There is no historical precedent for a technology delivering mass voluntary leisure.

Against the mainstream pessimistic reading of this track:

1. Unconditional income does not cause people to stop working en masse: Alaska (no employment effect), Finland (small effect), Kenya (no fall in total labour), OpenResearch (modest fall).
2. Over 80 years, new work has repeatedly appeared: Autor et al. 2024. Telephone operator automation did not reduce employment for later cohorts: Feigenbaum and Gross 2024.
3. Forecasts of mass technological unemployment (Leontief, Frey and Osborne) have so far been wrong in timing and scale.
4. The Jahoda meta-analysis found no status/identity deficit for people out of the labour force (as opposed to unemployed). This hints that the stigma of unemployment, rather than the absence of work as such, may drive part of the harm.

Against the optimistic history:

- The people displaced bore the costs (telephone operators; Acemoglu and Restrepo's local robot effects). New work arrived for the next cohort, not for the incumbents. If AI displacement is faster than 1920-1940 switchboard automation, there is less cohort turnover to absorb it.

Open questions

- Solo operators (partly answered in the gap-fill pass): still need 2024-2025 nonemployer counts and receipts when published, BTOS AI use split by firm size, and the primary sources for Medvi (FDA warning letter 721455, California docket, NYT profile). Original note: pull US Census Nonemployer Statistics (latest release, likely reference year 2022 or 2023), Census Business Formation Statistics (2024-26 business applications, especially high-propensity applications), ONS Labour Force Survey self-employment (UK self-employment has not returned to its pre-pandemic level, but the figure is not verified here), and the BTOS AI-use supplement split by firm size. Is there any measurable post-2023 rise in nonemployer firms or revenue per nonemployer that could plausibly be attributed to AI?
- "One-person billion-dollar company": trace Sam Altman's claim (2024) and find any actual solo or tiny-team companies with large valuations or exits (e.g. the Base44 sale to Wix in 2025 was reported at about $80m with a solo founder; this is unverified here).

- Care sector (partly answered): is anyone moving from AI-exposed occupations into care? No flow data found. Check the 2026 Skills for Care pay report against the April 2026 NLW.
- OpenResearch: reconcile 1.3 hrs/week and 2 pp with the 3.9 pp and about $2,000/yr figures. Get the detailed time-use table (leisure vs care vs education).
- Kenya UBI: are there long-run (2025-26) results from the 12-year arm?
- Four-day week: still no independent randomised evaluation found; Spain national pilot results and Tokyo uptake numbers not found; check the University of Münster's own publication for the German pilot (methods, any wearable or cortisol measures).
- Retirement: does retirement improve or harm wellbeing and cognition? This is the closest natural experiment for voluntary non-work with secure income.
- AI and job quality: are there field (not lab) studies of GenAI and meaning or autonomy, e.g. OECD worker surveys, Eurofound, or UK AI Security Institute and ONS opinions data?
- Gramatneusiedl: exact participant n, and whether effects persisted after the 2024 end of the pilot.

What's genuinely uncertain

- Whether AI is mainly an automation or an augmentation technology in the Autor et al. sense. That decides whether "new work" appears at scale.
- Whether the harm of losing work comes from losing income, losing structure, or losing status in a society that values employment. Existing evidence cannot separate them cleanly. A world of secure income and no stigma has never been observed.
- Whether freed time would be used differently if it came to everyone at once (a social norm) rather than to individuals in a treatment group or to the unemployed.
- Whether the work-intensification finding is a transitional effect of early tools and management norms or a lasting feature.
- Whether solo AI-enabled businesses are a real trend or a set of anecdotes. The headline cases rest on outsourced labour, and the official series that would show a trend stop at 2023 (US) or point down (UK).

Numbers for the facts file

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
~60% (some versions 63%)	Share of 2018 US employment in job titles that did not exist in 1940	Autor, Chin, Salomons, Seegmiller, QJE	https://economics.mit.edu/sites/default/files/2026-04/New-Frontiers-QJE-v139%283%29-p1399-1465-Aug-2024.pdf	Aug 2024	Peer-reviewed. Search summary only; not checked against PDF
41% to 1.9%	Agriculture share of US workforce, 1900 to 2000	USDA ERS (compiling HSUS and Census)	https://webharvest.gov/peth04/20041105150816/http://www.ers.usda.gov/publications/agoutlook/jun2000/ao272h.pdf	Jun 2000	Official, but seen via repost; other series give 2.4% for 2000
>25% fall; vs ~780 hrs	Fall in men's annual market hours 1931-2011, vs Keynes's implied target	Crafts, CEPR DP16140	https://repec.cepr.org/repec/cpr/ceprdp/DP16140.pdf	2021	Working paper; search summary only
47%	Share of US employment at "high risk" of computerisation	Frey and Osborne via ITIF	https://itif.org/publications/2022/09/30/oops-the-predicted-47-percent-of-job-loss-from-ai-didnt-happen/	2013 (forecast); 2022 (review)	Forecast; ITIF is an advocacy think tank
+16.4%	Employment growth 2013-2021 in insurance	ITIF	same as above	Sep 2022	Advocacy source using BLS data

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
	underwriters (highest F&O risk)				
-0.2 pp; -0.42%	Employment-to-population and wage effect per extra robot per 1,000 workers	Acemoglu and Restrepo, JPE	https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:ucp:jpolec:doi:10.1086/705716	2020	Peer-reviewed; other versions give different magnitudes
>50%	Share of US phone network AT&T automated 1920-1940	Feigenbaum and Gross, QJE	https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:oup:qjecon:v:139:y:2024:i:3:p:1879-1939.	Aug 2024	Peer-reviewed; search summary only
~1.3 hrs/ week; ~2 pp	Fall in hours and employment, $1,000/ month recipients vs controls	OpenResearch / Vivalt et al., NBER WP 32719 (via Fortune)	https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w32719/w32719.pdf	Jul 2024	RCT; figures from secondary coverage; a conference version reports 3.9 pp participation fall; reconcile
28% to 40% (control 32% to 37%)	Full-time employment, Stockton SEED recipients, Feb 2019 to Feb 2020	Martin-West and Castro Baker	https://catalog.results4america.org/case-studies/guaranteed-income-stockton	Mar 2021	n=125 treated; small
€560/month, ~2,000 people	Finland basic income experiment design	Finnish Ministry of Social Affairs and Health / Kela	https://stm.fi/en/-/perustulokokeilun-tulokset-tyollisyysvaikutukset-vahaisia-toimeentulo-ja-psyykkinen-terveys-koettiin-paremmaksi	May 2020	RCT; employment effect "small"
0 employment effect; +1.8 pp (17%) part-time	Alaska PFD labour effects	Jones and Marinescu, AEJ: Policy	https://www.aeaweb.org/doi/10.1257/pol.20190299	2022	Peer-reviewed; synthetic control; part-time figure conflicts with one text fragment
61 firms, ~2,900 staff; 56 continue, 18 permanent	UK four-day-week pilot	Autonomy / 4 Day Week Global, via WEF	https://www.weforum.org/stories/2023/03/four-day-work-week-uk-trial/	Feb 2023	Self-selected firms; advocacy-run
>2,500 workers, ~1% of workforce, 35-36 hrs	Iceland public-sector hours-reduction trials	Autonomy and Alda	https://issuu.com/4dayweekglobal/docs/iceland_4dw	Jun 2021	Advocacy report; not a four-day week
86%	Icelandic workers on contracts with shortened hours or the right to shorten	Autonomy and Alda	https://issuu.com/4dayweekglobal/docs/iceland_4dw	Jun 2021	Advocacy report; size of cuts varies
10-15% per year; 1.0-1.5 yrs	Mortality hazard increase 20 years after displacement; implied life-expectancy loss	Sullivan and von Wachter, QJE	https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:oup:qjecon:v:124:y:2009:i:3:p:1265-1306.	2009	Peer-reviewed; 50-100% first-year figure is from a draft only
~30% vs ~1%	Share of lost work hours going to sleep plus TV vs job search, Great Recession	Aguiar, Hurst, Karabarbounis (NBER Digest)	https://www.nber.org/digest/nov11/time-use-during-recessions	Nov 2011	ATUS-based; secondary summary
N=3,562; ~-11% motivation, ~+20% boredom	GenAI collaboration followed by solo work	Scientific Reports (4 experiments)	https://fortune.com/2025/06/03/ai-boost-worker-productivity-hurts-motivation-boredom	Apr 2025 (paper)	Online experiments; effect sizes from secondary coverage
3-7%	Share of chatbot productivity gains	Humlum and Vestergaard,	https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:nbr:nberwo:33777	2025	Danish register data, 25,000 workers; working paper

Figure	What it measures	Source	URL	Date	Reliability note
	passed through to earnings	NBER WP 33777			
~5,671,836	US business applications, 2025 (annual record)	Census BFS (annual sum via secondary)	https://www.census.gov/econ/bfs/pdf/historic/bfs_2025m12.pdf	Jan 2026	Official monthly data; annual total from secondary sum
37.6% to 30.1%	High-propensity share of US business applications, 2019 to 2025	Consultant calculation from Census BFS	https://founderreports.com/how-many-businesses-are-started-each-year/	2026	Secondary calculation
29.8m (2022); 30.4m (2023)	US nonemployer businesses	Census NES / NES-D	https://www.census.gov/library/stories/2025/07/nonemployer-business-growth.html	Jul / Nov 2025	Official; search extract
4.9%; 4.7%	Nonemployer growth 2021, 2022 (employer: 1.9%, 1.8%)	Census	https://www.census.gov/library/stories/2025/07/nonemployer-business-growth.html	Jul 2025	Official; pre-AI period
~4.38m vs ~5.0m	UK self-employed, Q4 2025 vs end-2019	ONS LFS via Statista	https://statista.com/statistics/318234/united-kingdom-self-employed	2026	LFS volatile; series disagree
~$401m; ~$65m	Medvi 2025 revenue; net profit	NYT via Dealroom	https://dealroom.co/news/127216-from-20k-to-1-8b-in-revenue-how-one-founder-built-a-telehealth-giant-wit/	Apr 2026	Journalist saw financials; contested; $1.8bn is a projection
~$80m + earn-out	Wix purchase of Base44 (6-8 staff, ~6 months old)	Globes	https://en.globes.co.il/en/article-wix-acquires-israeli-vibe-coding-co-base44-1001513267	Jun 2025	Press report
6.2%; ~96,000	England adult social care vacancy rate and vacancies, 2025/26	Skills for Care via LocalGov	https://www.localgov.co.uk/Social-care-vacancy-rate-falls-to-decade-low-but-challenges-ahead/64563	Jun 2026	Sector data body; secondary report
£12.60 (39p above NLW)	Median care worker hourly pay, England, Dec 2025	Skills for Care via Healthcare Management	https://www.healthcare-management.uk/care-workers-pay-minimum-wage-reveals	2026	Sector data; NLW rose to £12.71 in Apr 2026
$34,900; +17%; 765,800/yr	US home health and personal care aides: median pay 2024; growth 2024-34; annual openings	BLS OOH	https://www.bls.gov/ooh/healthcare/home-health-aides-and-personal-care-aides.htm	2025	Official; search extract
45 firms, ~900 staff; ~73% continue	Germany four-day-week pilot 2024	University of Münster / Intraprenör via The Local	https://www.thelocal.de/20241106/what-are-the-results-of-germanys-four-day-work-week-trial	Nov 2024	Self-selected; ~20% reverted
9.5%	Traffic fall during Valencia's four Monday holidays, 2023	City-commissioned evaluation via The Mayor	https://www.themayor.eu/en/a/view/valencia-s-government-says-4-day-week-trial-was-good-for-the-people-and-the-city-12172	2023	Four weeks; holidays not work redesign

Verbatim quotes

None. No page could be fetched in this session, so no wording could be checked against source text. Candidate quotes to verify later (paraphrased here, not to be quoted until checked):

- Keynes (1930): suggested three-hour shifts or a fifteen-hour week would satisfy most people's need to work. Source to fetch: the original essay text.
- Will Stronge (Autonomy research director, July 2021): called the Iceland trials the world's largest public-sector shorter-working-week trial and "an overwhelming success" (as reported

in syndicated news, e.g. https://www.fox5ny.com/news/4-day-work-week-trials-in-iceland-deemed-overwhelming-success-by-researchers).

- Autor (MIT): said roughly six in ten jobs people do today did not exist in 1940 (reported in MIT coverage).
- Case and Deaton (2018 reply to Ruhm): said "deaths of despair" was a label, not an explanation. https://www.princeton.edu/~accase/downloads/Case_and_Deaton_Comment_on_CJRuhm_Jan_2018.pdf
- Jahoda/Marienthal: free time experienced by the unemployed as a "tragic gift" (as summarised in the Paul et al. 2023 meta-analysis).

Sources worth reading in full

1. Autor, Chin, Salomons, Seegmiller, "New Frontiers", QJE 2024: the best evidence on where new work comes from, and on the automation vs augmentation split that should frame any "what will people do" argument. https://economics.mit.edu/sites/default/files/2026-04/New-Frontiers-QJE-v139%283%29-p1399-1465-Aug-2024.pdf
2. Feigenbaum and Gross, "Answering the Call of Automation", QJE 2024: a clean case of automation in a clerical occupation, separating cohort effects from incumbent effects. https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w28061/w28061.pdf
3. Vivalt et al., OpenResearch, NBER WP 32719: the largest US cash RCT, with time-use data on what people actually did. https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w32719/w32719.pdf
4. Kasy and Lehner, "Employing the unemployed of Marienthal", IZA DP 16088: the direct test of Jahoda's latent functions. https://docs.iza.org/dp16088.pdf
5. Humlum and Vestergaard, NBER WP 33777: large-scale register evidence on what chatbots have done to hours and earnings. https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:nbr:nberwo:33777
6. Paul et al. 2023 meta-analysis of the latent deprivation model: tests which of work's non-pay functions matter. https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10017486
7. Sullivan and von Wachter, QJE 2009: the hardest number on the human cost of job loss. https://www.movingforwardnetwork.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/04/Sullivan_Job-Displacement-and-Mortality_2009.pdf
8. Crafts, "Economic Possibilities for our Grandchildren revisited": a quantified check of Keynes. https://repec.cepr.org/repec/cpr/ceprdp/DP16140.pdf
9. Banerjee et al., Kenya UBI short-term results: a counterpoint showing cash funding enterprise, not leisure. https://conference.nber.org/conf_papers/f192616.pdf
10. Autonomy/Alda Iceland report: read it to see how thin the design is behind the "overwhelming success" headline. https://issuu.com/4dayweekglobal/docs/iceland_4dw
11. Census, "Number of U.S. Nonemployers Grew Faster Than Employer Businesses" (July 2025): the baseline for any claim about a solo-business boom. https://www.census.gov/library/stories/2025/07/nonemployer-business-growth.html
12. Skills for Care, State of the adult social care sector and workforce (2025/26) and pay report: the best data on whether care can absorb displaced workers, and at what pay. https://www.localgov.co.uk/Social-care-vacancy-rate-falls-to-decade-low-but-challenges-ahead/64563